Honecker's travels took him to Munich, where he held talks with Franz Josef Strauss in the Bavarian State Chancellery before visiting the Dachau concentration camp to meet with survivors. He was back in East Berlin that same evening. For all its publicity value, there were no breakthroughs on human rights or disarmament in what was primarily a symbolic gesture of goodwill between the two German states.

It was also clear that despite their close contacts, the two leaders had little natural affinity. However, their 'frank exchange of views' secured agreement on intensifying bilateral contacts in fields such as sports, improving rail connections to Berlin, expansion and repair of motorways and measures for environmental protection, including the desulphurisation of the GDR lignite industry. A further relaxation of travel visas to East Berlin (the FRG wanted tourists to be able to spend two days there) were delayed due to Honecker's concerns over drugs and AIDS – two perils he claimed were spread by the daily flood of tourists from the West. He also expressed reluctance to commit himself fully to Bonn's wish to allow visitors from the West to take bicycles into the GDR. However, it was agreed to ease restrictions on the importation of reading matter (technical or professional periodicals), cassette tapes and videos from the FRG. The visit, for Honecker, at least, had been spectacularly successful. 'In the future,' lamented a Christian Democrat politician in West Germany, 'we will have to do with an even more self-confident GDR.'5

In a revealing interview with Belgian journalists on 14 October 1987, the General Secretary was asked, 'The reforms being carried out in the Soviet Union seem not to have hit upon a particularly positive echo in the GDR. Do you think that they are little suited to the country you lead?'6 Although Honecker assured journalists that they had the 'wrong impression', he explained the restructuring introduced in the Soviet Union was being followed in the GDR with 'much sympathy and great interest':

As you know, for decades' friendship and constantly deepening cooperation with the Soviet Union have been a basic pillar of our policies. The